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so beat john's death words down
on me in the darker part
of evening. the black light issued
from him in the pit he made
around us. worms came clear 30
to me where i thought i had been
brilliant. o john death will
not contain you death
will not contain you

1969

JUNE JORDAN
1936–2002

Like her life of multiple identities and commitments ("I am Black and I am female and I am a mother and I am bisexual and I am a nationalist and I am an anti-nationalist. And I mean to be fully and freely all that I am!"), June Jordan's writings consist of myriad voices that together rebuke injustice and violation, resist the reduction of identity to categories, affirm communal and personal self-determination, and yearn for liberation. These voices come to sing and to scream, to orchestrate lyrical encounters with sharp-edged realities, while simultaneously putting themselves into question, persistently negotiating the complex relations between self and other, poetic expression and political struggle, aesthetic possibility and communal confrontation.

Jordan was born in Harlem, New York, on July 9, 1936, to Granville and Mildred Jordan, Jamaican natives who had escaped a life of poverty by emigrating to the United States. Despite their pride in their new American identity, the Jordans also had to contend with the racial tensions of their new country. Jordan's upbringing as a first-generation American in the black urban ghetto had a distinct influence on her writings, as did her tumultuous home life. In her essays and poems, she details her turbulent relationship with her father, who referred to her as "he," projecting his desire for a son instead of a daughter. In *Soldier: A Poet's Childhood* (2001), Jordan vividly recalls the alternating volatility and tenderness of the first twelve years of her life, including the abuse she often suffered at the hands of her father: "Like a growling beast, the roll-away mahogany doors rumble open, and the light snaps on and a fist smashes into the side of my head and I am screaming awake: 'Daddy! What did I do?!'" But Jordan's father, an admirer of black nationalist Marcus Garvey, also instilled in her a passion for literature and awareness of racial politics that mirrored his own; as a child, she read religious verse, Shakespeare, Edgar Allan Poe, and Paul Laurence Dunbar.

Jordan was also profoundly influenced by the limits of her mother's life, especially her mother's thwarted desire to be an artist. In poems such as "Getting Down to Get Over" (1977) and in the essay "Many Rivers to Cross" (1985), Jordan places her mother's life and eventual suicide in the context of the long-neglected history of black women everywhere: "momma / help me / turn the face of history *to your face*." Throughout her career Jordan sought to redress that neglect, critiquing versions of Western feminism that do not adequately consider issues of race, class, or motherhood.

It was during the early 1960s that Jordan began publishing poems, stories, and essays (under the name June Meyer, having married Michael Meyer, a white anthropology student at Columbia University she met while earning her B.A. at Barnard) in *Esquire, The Nation, Evergreen Review, Partisan Review, Black World, Black Creation, Essence*, the *Village Voice*, the *New York Times*, and elsewhere. The Harlem Riot of 1964 was a turning point for Jordan's commitment to blending activism and art. After the riot, Jordan was "filled with hatred for everything and everyone white," further concretizing her commitment to the Black Arts and Black Power movements: "This is a battle I have attempted to help define, and forward as though my own life depended on its success. In truth, my life does depend on the outcome of our Black struggles for freedom to be ourselves, in self-respecting self-sufficiency." But learning to struggle without hatred is the source from which sprang the best of Jordan's early poetry: reflections on the Harlem Riot were the occasion, Jordan writes, when "I resolved not to run on hatred but, instead, to use what I loved, words, for the sake of the people I loved." That resolution, however, was itself always a struggle, since it bore—in the very (white English) language of its utterance—the wounds of rupture, loss, division, violence, and the consciousness of exile: "But as a Black poet and writer, I hate words that cancel my name and my history and the freedom of my future: I hate the words that condemn and refuse the language of my people in America."

Driven by this tension within the very words she employed as weapons against oppression, Jordan examined throughout her work the relationship between power and language, particularly the quality of resistance embodied in black English. Jordan championed black English in much of her writing, celebrating its beauty and its efficacy most notably in her first novel, *His Own Where* (1970), which was written entirely in black English twelve years before Alice Walker's better known novel *The Color Purple* (1982). In response to attacks on the language of *His Own Where*, Jordan published the incisive essay "White English / Black English: The Politics of Translation," declaring that any longing for black self-determination must disrupt the hegemony of "standard" (i.e., white) English and assert black English as the medium of autonomous blackness: "Language is political. That's why you and me, my Brother and my Sister, that's why we sposed to choke our natural self into the weird, lying, barbarous, unreal, white speech and writing habits that the school lay down like holy law. Because, in other words, the powerful don't play; they mean to keep that power, and those who are the powerless (you and me) better shape up—mimic/ape/suck—in the very image of the powerful, or the powerful will destroy you—you and our children." And yet she observes, too, that the resisting power of black language—"magical and basic and irresistible"—is also the possibility of loss, suffering, fragmentation; and thus language for Jordan becomes the embattled, scarred, and disfigured terrain of the confrontation between transcendental yearning and functional, material struggle, a continuous "process of translation"—in short, "a political process" in which rupture and redress, loss and love, privation and purpose perpetually mix.

Fittingly, then, descriptions of Jordan's life and writing emphasize her determination to defy easy categorization. The sentiment is exemplified in one of her most famous poems, "Poem about My Rights," with its defiant refrain: "I am not wrong: Wrong is not my name / My name is my own my own my own." Such clear-cut resistance to labeling, to any kind of censorship or limitation, is also central to Jordan's second essay collection, *On Call* (1985), which focuses on worldwide liberation struggles in places such as Palestine, Nicaragua, and South Africa. Jordan's courageous public stands on the causes she championed often incited controversy; in the early 1980s, for instance, major media outlets and her own publisher refused to print her work because she adamantly supported the Palestinian liberation movement.

Pivotal to Jordan's writing career was her commensurate role as an educator. From children's writing workshops in Brooklyn to her final post as professor of African American studies and women's studies at the University of California at Berke-

ley, the classroom served as a vital performative and pedagogical space for Jordan's political activism and literary inspiration. As founding director of Berkeley's successful Poetry for the People program, Jordan worked with undergraduates and high school students, encouraging them to use poetry as a tool for self-expression and self-empowerment.

From activism to teaching and to writing, all of June Jordan's endeavors were informed by her philosophical assertions that our lives are "an intimate face of universal struggle" and that "by declaring the truth, you create truth." At the same time, Jordan moved among positions of black nationalism; international feminism; gay, lesbian, and bi-sexual activism; and neo-Marxism, always trying to confound any perspective that would not take dynamic account of the ways in which power is inscribed within the complex relations of race, class, gender, and sexuality. Thus Jordan's writing moves constantly between subjective and objective experience, articulating differing claims in mutual implication: "You begin with your family and the kids on the block, and next you open your eyes to what you call your people and that leads you into land reform into Black English into Angola leads you back to your own bed where you lie by yourself, wondering if you deserve to be peaceful, or trusted or desired or left to the freedom of your own unfaltering heart." Both self-questioning and provocatively assertive, Jordan's narrative takes place in a language that is itself articulated in many accents and different dialects, in both "black" and "white" English, taking place in both local and global frameworks.

Even amid controversy and failing health, Jordan remained a strong, passionate, and vibrant presence in the literary world. She received numerous awards and honors for her work and activism throughout her lifetime, including a 1972 National Book Award nomination for *His Own Where*, the National Association of Black Journalists Award, and various fellowships from the Massachusetts Council of the Arts, the National Endowment for the Arts, and the New York Foundation for the Arts. She was also awarded the Distinguished Alumna Award from Barnard in 1997.

June Jordan died of breast cancer at her home in Berkeley on June 14, 2002. During one of her final public speaking engagements, at the thirtieth anniversary celebration of Barnard's Center for Research on Women in 2001, Jordan read from the title poem of her last book, *Some of Us Did Not Die* (2002). In the poem she invokes the image of a Nietzschean predatory hawk swooping over her dying body: "He makes that dive / to savage / me / and inches / from the blood flood lusty / beak / I roll away / I speak / I laugh out loud / Not yet / big bird of prey / not yet."

In Memoriam: Martin Luther King, Jr.[1]

I

honey people murder mercy U.S.A.
the milkland turn to monsters teach
to kill to violate pull down destroy
the weakly freedom growing fruit
from being born 5

America

tomorrow yesterday rip rape
exacerbate despoil disfigure

1. Co-founder of the Southern Christian Leadership Conference and civil rights leader (1929–1968); Jordan wrote this poem shortly after King's assassination in April 1968.

crazy running threat the
deadly thrall 10
appall belief dispel
the wildlife burn the breast
the onward tongue
the outward hand
deform the normal rainy 15
riot sunshine shelter wreck
of darkness derogate
delimit blank
explode deprive
assassinate and batten up 20
like bullets fatten up
the raving greed
reactivate a springtime
terrorizing

death by men by more 25
than you or I can

STOP

II

They sleep who know a regulated place
or pulse or tide or changing sky
according to some universal 30
stage direction obvious
like shorewashed shells

we share an afternoon of mourning
in between no next predictable
except for wild reversal hearse rehearsal 35
bleach the blacklong lunging
ritual of fright insanity and more
deplorable abortion
more and
more 40

1968

Gettin Down to Get Over

Dedicated to my mother

MOMMA MOMMA MOMMA
momma momma
mammy
nanny
granny 5
woman
mistress
sista

luv

blackgirl
slavegirl

gal

honeychile
sweetstuff
sugar
sweetheart
baby
Baby Baby

MOMMA MOMMA
Black Momma
Black bitch
Black pussy
piecea tail
nice piecea ass

hey daddy! hey
bro!
we walk together (an')
talk together (an')
dance and *do*
(together)
dance and do/hey!
daddy!
bro!
hey!
nina nikki nonni nommo nommo[1]
momma Black
Momma

Black Woman
Black
Female Head of Household
Black Matriarchal Matriarchy
Black Statistical
Lowlife Lowlevel Lowdown
Lowdown and *up*
to be Low-down
Black Statistical
Low Factor
Factotem
Factitious Fictitious
Figment Figuring in Lowdown Lyin
Annual Reports[2]

1. Originally referring to hermaphroditic ancestral spirits worshipped by the Dogon in Mali, *nommo* came to denote the transformative power of speech among African and African American social movements of the 1960s and 1970s.

2. The references in this stanza are to government-agency reports on low-income citizens.

Black Woman/Black
Hallelujah Saintly
patient
smilin
humble
givin thanks
for
Annual Reports and
Monthly Dole[3]
and
Friday night
and
(*good* God!)
Monday mornin: Black and Female
martyr masochist
(A BIG WHITE LIE)
Momma Momma

What does Mothafuckin mean?
WHO'S THE MOTHAFUCKA
FUCKED MY MOMMA
messed yours over
and right now
be trippin on[4] my starveblack
female soul
a macktruck[5]
mothafuck
the first primordial
the paradig/digmatic
dogmatistic mothafucka who
is he?
hey!
momma momma

dry eyes on the
shy/dark/hidden/cryin Black
face
of the loneliness
the rape
the brokeup mailbox
an' no western union roses[6]
come inside the kitchen
and no poem
take you through the whole night
and no big
Black
burly
hand
be holdin yours

3. Government welfare.
4. "Trippin on": becoming angry at.
5. Anything large (after the Mack brand of commercial trucks).
6. The Western Union telegram company introduced gift telegrams with candy and flowers in the 1960s.

to have to hold onto
no
big Black burly hand
no nommo
no Black prince
come riding from the darkness
on a beautiful black horse
no bro
no daddy

"I was sixteen when I met my father.
In a bar.
In Baltimore.
He told me who he was
and what he does.
Paid for the drinks.
I looked.
I listened.
And I left him.
It was civil
perfectly
and absolute bull
shit.
The drinks was leakin waterweak
and never got down to my knees."

hey daddy
what they been and done to you
and what you been and done
to me
to momma
momma momma
hey
sugar daddy
big daddy
sweet daddy
Black Daddy
The Original Father Divine[7]
the everlovin
deep
tall
bad
buck[8]
jive[9]
cold
strut
bop[1]
split
tight

7. Reverend Major Jealous Divine (1876–1967), African American spiritual leader.
8. Racial slur for black man, connoting an irredeemably violent, rude, lecherous rebel against white authority.
9. Sly, clever, or deceitful (slang).
1. Rebellious (after the 1940s avant-garde jazz form called "Bebop").

loose
close
hot
hot
hot
sweet SWEET DADDY
WHERE YOU BEEN AND
WHEN YOU COMIN BACK TO ME
HEY
WHEN YOU COMIN BACK
TO MOMMA
momma momma

And Suppose He Finally Say
"Look, Baby.
I Loves Me Some
Everything about You.
Let Me Be Your Man."
That reach around the hurtin
like a dream.
And I ain never wakin up
from that one.
momma momma
momma momma

II

Consider the Queen

hand on her hip
sweat restin from
the corn/bean/greens' field
steamy under the pale/sly
suffocatin sun

Consider the Queen

she fix the cufflinks
on his Sunday shirt
and fry some chicken
bake some cake
and tell the family
"Never mine about the bossman
don' know how a human
bein spozed to act. Jus'
never mind about him.
Wash your face.
Sit down. And let
the good Lord bless this table."

Consider the Queen

her babies pullin at the nipples
pullin at the momma milk

the infant fingers gingerly
approach caress the
soft/Black/swollen/momma breast

and there
inside the mommasoft
life-spillin treasure chest
the heart
breaks

rage by grief by sorrow
weary weary
breaks
breaks quiet
silently
the weary sorrow
quiet now the furious
the adamant the broken
busted beaten down and beaten up
the beaten beaten beaten
weary heart beats
tender-steady
and the babies suck/
the seed of blood
and love glows at the
soft/Black/swollen momma breast

Consider the Queen

she works when she works
in the laundry *in jail*
in the school house *in jail*
in the office *in jail*
on the soap box *in jail*
on the desk
on the floor
on the street
on the line[2]
at the door
lookin fine
at the head of the line
steppin sharp from behind
in the light
with a song
wearing boots
or a belt
and a gun
drinkin wine when it's time
when the long week is done
but she works when she works
in the laundry in jail
she works when she works

2. I.e., factory assembly line.

Consider the Queen

she sleeps when she sleeps
with the king in the kingdom
she
sleeps when she sleeps
with the wall
with whatever it is who happens
to call
with me and with you
(to survive you make
do/you explore more and more)
so she sleeps when she sleeps
a really deep sleep

Consider the Queen

a full/Black/glorious/a purple rose
aroused by the tiger breathin
beside her
a shell with the moanin
of ages inside her
a hungry one feedin the folk
what they need

Consider the Queen.

III

Blackman
let that white girl go
She know what you ought to know.
(By now.)

IV

MOMMA MOMMA
momma momma
family face
face of the family alive
momma
mammy
momma
woman
sista
baby
luv

the house on fire/
poison waters/
earthquake/
and the air a nightmare/
turn

turn
turn around the
national gross product[3]
growin
really gross/turn
turn
turn the pestilence away
the miserable killers
and Canarsie
Alabama[4]
people beggin to be people
warfare on the welfare
of the folk/
hey
turn
turn away
the trickbag[5] university/the
trickbag propaganda/
trickbag
tricklins of prosperity/of
pseudo-"status"
lynchtree necklace
on the strong
round
neck of you
my momma
momma momma
turn away
the f.b.i./the state police/the cops/
the/everyone of the
infest/incestuous investigators
into you
and Daddy/into us
hey
turn
my mother
turn
the face of history
to your own
and please be smilin
if you can
be smilin
at the family

momma momma

let the funky[6] forecast
be the last
one we will ever
want to listen to

3. Gross National Product (GNP), the value of all labor and goods produced nationally each year.
4. The Canarsie subway line in Brooklyn emerges at Alabama Avenue.
5. Deceptively scheming.
6. Weird eccentric, pungent.

And Daddy see
the stars fall down
and burn a light
into the singin
darkness of your eyes
my Daddy
my Blackman
you take my body in
your arms/you use
the oil of coconuts/of trees and
flowers/fish and new fruits
from the new world
to enflame me in this otherwise
cold place
please

meanwhile
momma
momma momma
teach me how to kiss
the king within the kingdom
teach me how to t.c.b.[7]/to make do
and be
like you
teach me to survive my
momma
teach me how to hold a new life
momma
help me
turn the face of history
to your face.

1972

From The Talking Back of Miss Valentine Jones: *Poem # One*

well I wanted to braid my hair
bathe and bedeck my
self so fine
so fully aforethought for
your pleasure
see:
I wanted to travel and read
and runaround fantastic
into war and peace:
I wanted to
surf
dive
fly
climb
conquer
and be conquered

7. Take care of business.